other states instead of sending central teams to Bengal. The defaming of our state is our main concern."

According to the PM Poshan Scheme, the cost of one daily hot meal is slated to be Rs 5.45 for each primary child (one- to five-year-olds) and Rs 7.97 for each upper primary child (six- to eight-year-olds). This excludes the cost of foodgrains (rice or wheat) that primary and upper primary children—100 gm and 150 gm, respectively—are entitled to and the cooking cost. The foodgrains are supplied free of cost by the Food Corporation of India (FCI). The purpose of the scheme is to meet the nutritional standards of children and to guard against diseases like anaemia and stunted growth. With daily allotment per child pegged at Rs 5.45/ Rs 7.97 and the number of school days at 220-240 a year, a lot of money is concentrated in the Poshan scheme for 11.5 million children in Bengal.

THE MODUS OPERANDI

According to many teachers INDIA TODAY spoke to, many schools allegedly inflate the number of the scheme's beneficiaries to divert funds, since it is based on a head count of children eating the meals. The most common practice is to show that 100 per cent of students entitled to the meal are eating it regularly, which is never actually the case. For instance, at a primary school in West Midnapore on February 17, only 40 out of 92 students attended classes. Ideally, the school should provide a true average picture of students eating meals. But this never happens. Instead, schools demand a full share of funds. This is also a way to use the rice/ wheat left in stock elsewhere.

There are other means to show a full utilisation of the mid-day meal. There has been a proliferation of private primary schools in Bengal's semi-urban areas, who are hand-in-glove with government schools. "Sabang block (in West Midnapore) has six private kindergarten schools with 150 students each. Parents admit their children to private primary schools, but want them to join government schools in higher classes—either because private ones have no secondary classes or are quite expensive. So a tacit understanding is arrived at—private schools allow government primary schools to show their students on records, so as to inflate their student strength and help them claim full Poshan funds. In exchange, they are assured that their students would get absorbed in government schools later," alleges Sabang BJP leader Amulya Maity.

A primary school teacher in Hingalgunj says, "There's a school here that has about 10 students. How does it function? Private primary schools lend them students. On average, 50 to 100 private school students make it to the government portal." Indeed, despite the state government's digital Banglar Shiksha portal maintaining data of each government school along with individual students, the practice continues. Teachers claim that the portal uploads whatever information a school provides, with no one to examine its veracity. School inspectors empowered to visit and verify information, including about mid-day meals, mostly depend on school data. Again, many government schools have opened hostels, where mid-day meal rations are allegedly used to feed hostel inmates even if they aren't covered under Poshan.

Then there are ration dealers/ distributors who have lifted a large stock of foodgrains for the scheme from the FCI. A senior bureaucrat says they keep aside a portion under the authorities' instruction. They also allegedly send a rice consignment three to four months in advance to schools so that parts are damaged, face complaint, and branded inedible. The dealer then takes back the entire stock, though much of it is in good condition. He either sells it in the open market or allegedly supplies it to ruling party leaders. When informed, FCI replenishes the whole stock. "This is a prevalent practice during the monsoon, when dealers push ration for three months at a go, knowing well the risk of flooding," says a headmaster of a school in Andul, in Howrah district.

Besides, there are widespread allegations that BDOs withhold mid-day meal funds for a month or two. Opposition parties like the BJP and CPI(M) allege this is done to enjoy the extra bank interest that accrues.

According to Talwar, the Poshan scheme in Bengal was worst hit during Covid. "During the lockdowns, when families faced starvation, children needed nutrition. But we found children in Bengal getting two kilos of rice and two kilos of potatoes a month, which was much below their entitlement," she says.

Going by such hard nutritional facts, the PM Poshan scheme in West Bengal needs to be put back on track. Else, its youngest generations may be pushed towards mass malnutrition. ■

NUTRITION WITHHELD

- A survey by the Right to Food campaign shows **11.5 million** children in West Bengal were deprived of **45,953 tonnes** of rice due to them under the PM Poshan scheme during the 2020-2022 Covid lockdown periods. Total value: **Rs 1,572 crore**
- Government schools allegedly claim full share of funds showing cent per cent attendance, when mostly only some students eat the mid-day meals regularly
- Funds thus siphoned off are allegedly used for other administrative purposes
- Many BDOs allegedly hold back funds for **1-2 months**, to avail of the bank interest accrued
- NFHS-5 figures show **34%** of Bengal's children below 5 are stunted, **20%** are wasted, **32%** are underweight